

guest column

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THE RAGE OF FASCISM

Once this silence of the graveyard is fully established, there won't be any problems with investment



Buddhababu and CPI(M) have repeatedly said that once they had announced no land would be taken in Nandigram, there was no need for a Bhoomi Uchhed Pratirodh Committee or any form of opposition. Basically, they wanted to say that all of this was the creation of the Opposition, the Trinamool Congress (TC) in particular, which was trying to instigate people to get political mileage out of it. No one will deny that—we have seen bandhs and roadblocks. As far as TC was concerned, Nandigram was a burning issue which it used quite indiscriminately. But did CPI(M) really want to put an end to the problem? Was it serious about trying to explain to the people? What Buddhababu, or any top CPI(M) leader, could have done was to have visited Nandigram and talked to the people there. Also, none of those who were convicted in the March 14 genocide, were actually punished. How could Buddhababu have earned the support of the villagers? I feel they never wanted to earn that. They wanted to keep the problem alive.

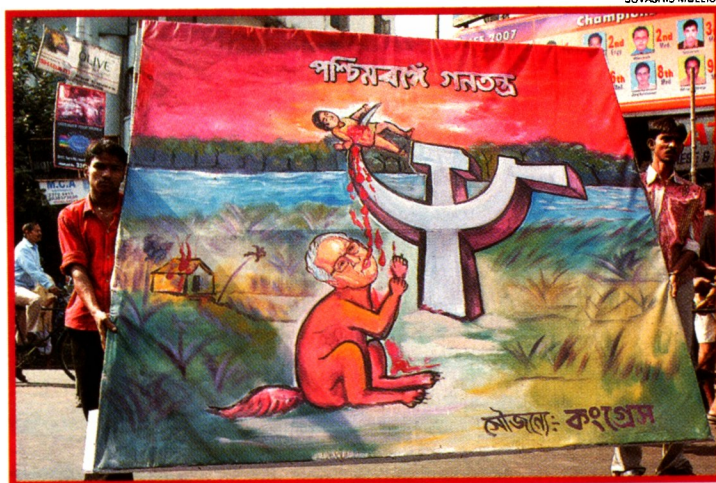
This might sound puzzling, because why would CPI(M) want the Opposition to gain mileage? To understand the puzzle, we have to look at the panchayat polls due next year. In the last panchayat polls in 2003, there were many violent incidents in which many homes were burnt. Look at the numbers. Out of the total number of seats CPI(M) had won, more than 16 per cent were uncontested. In the panchayat samiti, it was a little lower but substantial, around 13 per cent. So terror did play a role in panchayat polls. It always does. But this year it was doubly important, because CPI(M) initially tried to acquire land arbitrarily, without paying proper compensation or talking to the people which gave rise to resentment. The party had apprehended a lot of opposition because of this. If you try to solve the problem in a normal way by sending the police or through talks, you cannot send across the message of terror—look, we are all powerful; don't mess with us, and TC cannot give you protection. This is precisely the message that CPI(M) has sent to the entire state so that it can sail

through the panchayat polls. I can't find any other reason why they didn't choose the administrative option instead.

In all fairness, one must admit that TC also tried to use terror at some point. With its muskets and country-made guns, however, it couldn't fight the SLRs and automatic rifles. It was a wonderfully-smooth and absolutely ruthless operation. CPI(M) had this particular objective in mind, and it has accomplished this.

Now, the question is, would all this affect industrial input in the state? There, my submission would be, fascism and industrialisation can go hand in hand. It has been proved time and again. In fact, industrialists or potential investors often prefer it that way. If we look at China, at the entire East Asia, or Mussolini's Italy or Franco's Spain, a high level of

economic growth took place during such regimes. Under a fascist regime, you cannot raise your voice, and that helps the investors. If the government is investor-friendly, there will be no opposition to whatever it wants. I believe in both democracy and capitalism and I certainly believe our only way out is industrialisation. But getting our democratic rights is different altogether. Industrialisation



per se will not guarantee democracy.

Lastly, I would like to raise a question. This awful mercenary operation must have cost a lot of money. Where did it come from? I don't have any solid evidence but most likely it came from the business people. Businessmen always want to be close to the government for their own reasons. The whole operation must be financed and this establishment of fascism was most likely sponsored by the business people. I don't think industrialists will have any problem coming to Bengal despite the incident. Once this silence of the graveyard is completely established, there won't be any problems with investment. And investors would like to have a government which is in control of the situation. Investment-wise Buddhababu has done the right thing. Democratic rights-wise, definitely not.

The author is a noted economist and a faculty member at the Indian Statistical Institute, Kolkata